



SMASHING RIGHT
H.S. Prannoy (top) in a semifinal match; Kidambi Srikanth (below) takes on Jonathan Christie

rocketed in the past few years. "There is a huge talent pool available. How you groom them is of utmost importance," Gopichand told INDIA TODAY. "We should ensure that we take care of it well. The grassroots and intermediate levels need to be nurtured properly. For this, we need a robust coaching system and perspective planning to enable talented players to reach their full potential."

Padukone, whose academy in Bengaluru has trained Sen since the age of 10, said BAI must seize the moment and take the game forward by setting up more academies across the country as it's not possible for everyone to join the two premier academies in Bengaluru and Hyderabad. Badminton can be an expensive proposition, especially for middle-class parents with aspirations that their child be the next Sindhu or Gopichand. "It will cost them about Rs 30,000-35,000 a month just to train and play properly. For many, it is tough to keep aside that sort of money. Despite that, many are into this," says Kumar. Costs mount once players start playing tournaments, especially international ones. Kumar lauds the government for supporting players during the pandemic with Khelo India scholarships and covering high salaries of the foreign coaches who are now open to a working stint in India.

Already in action mode, BAI has identified coaching academies in Panchkula, Haryana and Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh, to cater to the needs of players from north India; Nagpur, Maharashtra, for those from central India; and Guwahati, Assam, for those from the Northeast. The UP centre is already operational and the Guwahati one will open its doors in September. Thirty coaches will be appointed to identify and nurture young talent. Moreover, BAI has approached the Badminton World Federation to seek an opportunity to host two Challengers tournaments. "Our objective will be to give the maximum number of young and talented players an opportunity to play international tournaments in India itself," says Sarma.

THE HOMECOMING

While most of the new icons stayed back to compete in the Thailand Open, Sen, who had battled food poisoning on his arrival in Bangkok, returned to India late on May 16. His mother Nirmala Sen and elder brother Chirag, also a badminton player, were at the Bengaluru airport to welcome him, coach-father D.K. Sen and Kumar with two boxes of milk *peda* and bouquets. The next day, Sen headed to the chief minister's office for a felicitation ceremony. "So many players are playing, but India doesn't have viewers," bemoaned Chirag Sen. That changed with the Thomas Cup, which made everyone take note of the Reliance-owned Sports18 channel or turn to Voot that streamed the finals for free.

"This is the start," said Prannoy. "We need to build on this and start creating more champions so that in the next 10 years you see two to three more Thomas Cups coming to India." Before May 15, this would have sounded like a pipe dream. Not anymore. ■